7 AI Agents Your Business Could Be Using Right Now

A practical guide to automate repetitive work, connect your tools and save hours every week.

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Understanding AI Agents

An AI agent is software that uses AI to understand a goal, choose a next step and use connected tools to carry it out. It checks the result and adjusts its actions within the limits your team sets.

A simple example

A customer asks about a delayed delivery. The agent checks the order and shipping status, then decides whether to answer or pass the case to your team.

How is it different from automation?

Traditional automation

Follows rules and steps defined in advance.

Example: Send a receipt when payment is confirmed.

AI agent

Chooses the next permitted action based on context and the results it finds.

Example: Investigate a delivery issue and decide what to do next.

Give it a clear job

Define the goal, the information it can access, the actions it may take and when it must ask for help. Use fixed rules for predictable steps and an agent where context matters.

Source: Anthropic, Building effective agents, December 2024.

Agents for sales and customer support

01 Sales Preparation Agent

Prepare your team for the next sales conversation. Review new enquiries, retrieve relevant CRM history and approved service information, then draft a brief and suggested follow-up.

Your business: A prospect asks about improving onboarding. The agent prepares questions for your salesperson and flags missing budget or timing.

Human review: Pricing, commitments and outbound messages.

Measure: Preparation time and corrections before use.

Real example: Microsoft reports that Fujitsu built a sales agent to support proposal creation and knowledge retrieval.

02 Customer Support Agent

Answer routine questions using approved help content and relevant account information. Pass complex cases to your team with a summary of the checks already completed.

Your business: A customer asks to change a delivery address. The agent checks the order stage, explains the options and routes exceptions to support.

Human review: Refunds and sensitive account changes.

Measure: Resolution rate, satisfaction and repeat contacts.

Real example: Lightspeed reported that Fin resolved 45–65% of support volume across its workspaces while customer satisfaction remained stable.

Reported results reflect individual implementations and are not guaranteed outcomes for your business.

Sources: Microsoft, April 2025; Intercom, Lightspeed customer interview.

Agents for onboarding and operations

03 Onboarding Agent

Guide a new customer or colleague through the next steps. Review submitted information, identify missing items and answer questions using approved guidance.

Your business: After a client signs, check the intake form against the agreed scope and prepare a checklist of missing documents.

Human review: Access permissions, scope changes and the final readiness decision.

Measure: Onboarding time and follow-up effort.

Real example: Microsoft reports that KPMG used an agent to help new hires find templates and historical references, reducing follow-up calls by 20%. This case concerns employee onboarding.

04 Operations and Document Agent

Reduce manual checks across documents and business systems. Extract information, find supporting records and flag mismatches.

Your business: Match an emailed invoice with its purchase order, then flag differences for a finance owner.

Human review: Payment approval, supplier changes and uncertain matches.

Measure: Review time, missed discrepancies and false alarms.

Real example: Microsoft's November 2024 Dow case describes a pilot that processed emailed PDF invoices and flagged billing issues for employee review.

Dow's wider savings were projections in that report, not completed results.

Sources: Microsoft, April 2025; Microsoft WorkLab, November 2024.

Agents for reporting and internal management

05 Reporting Agent

Prepare updates from approved data. Investigate changes and draft a summary with evidence. Use reporting tools for calculations.

Your business: Investigate overdue work and prepare questions for a weekly review. Label possible explanations as hypotheses.

Human review: A manager checks the interpretation.

Measure: Preparation time and factual corrections.

Real example: Microsoft reports that Estée Lauder's ConsumerIQ agent helps teams access consumer data and identify trends.

06 Internal Knowledge Agent

Help your team find process guidance in approved documents, with source links and access based on permissions.

Your business: A colleague asks which expenses need approval. The agent finds the policy and explains the next step.

Human review: Policy owners keep the guidance accurate.

Real example: Microsoft time and factual corrections.

Real example: Microsoft reports that Wells Fargo introduced an agent giving employees access to guidance on 1,700 internal procedures.

07 Task Coordination Agent

Turn updates into proposed next steps. Compare meeting notes with your project board, identify blockers and draft task updates.

Your business: A delivery is delayed. The agent checks affected tasks and drafts an update for the project owner.

Human review: People confirm owners, deadlines and priorities.

Source for documented examples: Microsoft, April 2025.

Choose the right work to automate

The best place to start is a recurring process with clear inputs, repeatable steps and an outcome your team can check.

A good first candidate

01 Repeated often
It comes up daily or weekly and takes meaningful team time.

02 Follows a known process
Your team can describe the usual steps and common exceptions.

03 Uses accessible information
The agent can work with current, approved information and limited permissions.

04 Has a measurable result
Track time saved, response speed, quality or errors before and after.

05 Has a safe handoff
Unclear, sensitive or unusual cases go to a person.

Start with one bounded task

Test it with real examples. Compare results with your current process. Expand only when your team trusts the outcome.

Source: Anthropic, Building Effective Agents, December 2024.

Is your business ready for AI Agents?

A strong pilot starts with an owned process, clear boundaries and a way to measure the result.

A practical readiness checklist

01 Clear owner
Someone is accountable for the process and its outcomes.

02 Documented steps
Your team knows the normal path and common exceptions.

03 Reliable information
The source data is current, accurate and accessible.

04 Scoped access
The agent has only the permissions and tools it needs.

05 Human review
Your team knows what the agent may do and when it must ask.

06 Success measure
You have a baseline for time, quality, cost or satisfaction.

If several answers are 'not yet'

Improve the process first. Then pilot one bounded task and review the results with the people who do the work.

Three workflows, from trigger to outcome

Illustrative blueprints you can adapt to your own processes.

01 Lead enquiry to first meeting

TRIGGER	A new enquiry arrives through your website or CRM.
AGENT	Check required details, retrieve relevant account and service information, then draft a tailored reply and call brief.
HUMAN CHECK	A salesperson confirms fit, pricing and claims before sending.
MEASURE	Time to first response and qualified meetings booked.

02 Support request to resolution

TRIGGER	A customer asks a question about an order or service.
AGENT	Identify the request, check order details and approved policies, then draft a routine answer.
HUMAN CHECK	A person handles refunds, exceptions and sensitive account changes.
MEASURE	First-contact resolution and repeat contacts.

03 Invoice to payment-ready review

TRIGGER	A supplier invoice arrives by email.
AGENT	Extract supplier, amount and due date; match the purchase order; flag discrepancies and prepare an approval task.
HUMAN CHECK	Finance verifies the match, coding and payment approval.
MEASURE	Processing time and discrepancies caught before payment.

Find your next automation opportunity

Use this simple score to decide which process deserves a closer look.

Score each factor from 0 to 2

01 Frequency
Rarely = 0 · Weekly = 1 · Daily = 2

02 Time spent
Under 1 hour/week = 0 · 1–5 hours = 1 · Over 5 hours = 2

03 Process clarity
Changes every time = 0 · Mostly repeatable = 1 · Clear steps = 2

04 Information access
Scattered or outdated = 0 · Partly accessible = 1 · Approved and accessible = 2

05 Human control
No clear review = 0 · Review is possible = 1 · Named owner and review = 2

TOTAL: _____ / 10

Read your score

0–4 Prepare the process or information first.

5–7 Choose a bounded pilot and record a baseline.

8–10 Strong candidate for a structured assessment.

A directional prioritisation tool, not a feasibility study or ROI guarantee.

Want to apply this to your business?

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